WEEK 9 · NOV 5 · READ FIRST

Making Presentations

Turning your pitch deck into slides that say what you found

Bring your Oct 22 pitch deck today, printed or open on a laptop to read from. Everything you write in this packet is by hand.

Aim for a change in your audience

Every talk tries to move people from where they are to somewhere else. A From/To table names that change for each person in the room, where they start and where you want them by the end. “I want them to be impressed” and “I want them to understand how it works” don’t say where you want them to end up.

Two steps to a clear slide

1. Distill your message. Decide what the audience should take from the slide, and put it in the title as a sentence. **2. Align visual emphasis.** Make the eye land on the evidence for that sentence.

Sentence titles

Topic title	Sentence title
Model validation	The model matched the observed damage grade at 8 of 10 Mayfield walls
Mesh convergence	Refining the mesh below 50 mm changed peak stress by less than 2%
Hidden steel strip analysis	Hidden steel strips kept the wall standing only to 128 mph, inside the EF2 range

A sentence title says who did what, makes a claim the evidence on the slide supports, and completes “Today I learned that…”. Two lines is fine. Read only your titles in order and they should tell the story. (Numbers here are illustrative.)

Three tools to steer the eye

1. Layer the slide

Background (axes, grid, labels) in light gray, data in a quiet color, and one strong color on the marks the title is about.

2. Match form to argument

Pick the chart for the comparison the title makes. Pick color for how the data relate (qualitative, accent, sequential, divergent). No rainbows.

3. Make the key check easy

Name what the audience has to do to verify the title. Put the things being compared next to each other, label directly, and pass the squint test.

Adapted from Ardon Shorr, “Clear thinking made visible” and “Pitching your research,” Princeton (2020). See also Michael Alley, *The Craft of Scientific Presentations* (2013).

WEEK 9 · WORKSHEET 1

Where Should Your Committee End Up?

Name the change you want your Dec 8 talk to make

Warm-up. Write your current key finding in one sentence. Read it to yourself. Could it sit at the top of a slide, with the evidence for it underneath?

Committee member and what they know best	**From** where they start	**To** where you want them by the end

Example. A structures member starts at “a simulation of a building that already collapsed can’t be trusted” and ends at “a model that reproduces Mayfield’s damage can rank retrofits.”

The one sentence you want the whole room to remember. This is the message of your talk.

Check before you move on

- [ ] Each To is something you could check after the talk. “Be impressed” and “understand it” don’t count.
- [ ] Your message sentence gets both people to their To.

WEEK 9 · WORKSHEET 2

Retitle Your Pitch Deck

One sentence title per slide of your Oct 22 deck

#	Current title	Sentence title	Does the slide show it?
1			yes partly no
2			yes partly no
3			yes partly no
4			yes partly no
5			yes partly no
6			yes partly no
7			yes partly no
8			yes partly no

For every “partly” or “no,” what changes? Either the title claims less, or the slide shows different evidence.

Check before you move on

- [ ] Read the sentence titles alone, in order. Do they walk the U from Week 6, from the goal down to your research question and back up to the benefit?
- [ ] No title is only a topic (Methods, Results, Validation, Future work).
- [ ] Expected results are still marked EXPECTED in the title.

WEEK 9 · WORKSHEET 3

Redesign One Figure

The figure your committee is most likely to stop on, drawn again by hand

Sentence title for this figure

Key task. What does the audience have to do to check the title? Compare two bars, read a trend, spot the one that is different…

Layer	Which marks, in your figure
Emphasis one strong color	
Data quiet color	
Background light gray	

What job does color do here? Circle one.

qualitative accent sequential divergent

Sketch the new figure, title on top

Squint test, with a partner

- [ ] Your partner squints at the sketch and says what they see first. Write it here. _____
- [ ] Is that the finding in your title? If not, what has to get quieter?

WEEK 9 · REFLECT AND CARRY FORWARD

Toward Dec 8

What you take into the committee talk

Which slide was hardest to give a sentence title, and why?

Which slide had a title its evidence couldn't support? What will you do about it?

What did your partner see first in your figure, and was it what you meant?

Before next week

Update your .pptx with the sentence titles and the redesigned figure. Send Becca the deck as a PDF, together with Worksheets 1 to 3.

The title of the slide your committee will remember.